

CONJURING TRICKS

magic takes center stage

Magic as performance was given a vast boost in the mid-1800s by Jean-Eugène Robert-Houdin (see pp.236–237), and continued to flourish into the next century. This was a golden age of magic: a big business, it filled theaters and its prime practitioners were celebrated. Magic had become spectacle, with the inexplicable made real in ever more dramatic ways. Never less than a series of elaborate illusions, performances placed an absolute premium on the magician as conjurer of the impossible.

Applause and acclaim

One central figure was Harry Kellar, an American magician who seemed to his audience to be in touch with the spirit world. In the late 1800s, he became the first stage magician to achieve international fame. A Chinese illusionist, Ching Ling Foo, also gained great acclaim; in his act he appeared to bring the beheaded back to life, to push blades through his nose without injury, and to produce a variety of animals—even children—from under a black cape.



▲ The original Chinese conjuror

Many of Beijing-born Ching Ling Foo's illusions were variations on Chinese magic. The air of mystery they produced entranced huge numbers throughout the US and Europe.

► Dicing with death

Houdini reveled in the notion that his apparently impossible challenges might prove fatal: in this famous stunt, he escaped from a straitjacket while suspended upside-down from a crane in New York.

Houdini supreme

Increasingly, the thrill of many acts lay not only in the conjurer's skills but in the miraculous avoidance of death. No magician encapsulated this better than Hungarian-born Harry Houdini. Showmanship personified, Houdini was an adept escapologist and technician who delighted in the impossible. His most famous acts demanded astonishing physical feats, but they were still tricks. In time, he became a firm opponent of false mediums who sought to pass themselves off as genuine.

Sleight of hand

In the early 20th century, two masters emerged in one of the oldest forms of performance magic—*legerdemain* (sleight of hand). Welsh-born Richard Pitchford (stage name “Cardini”) could produce, as if from nowhere, vast numbers of playing cards arranged in perfect fans. Slightly later, American magician Channing Pollock was the original exponent of the dove fluttering from a silk handkerchief. No one presumed such feats were actual magic, but they rarely failed to astound.



“What he did seemed impossible.
Was he really nothing more
than a mere illusionist?”

RUTH BRANDON, *THE LIFE AND MANY DEATHS OF HARRY HOUDINI*, 1993